

US Presidential Inaugural Speeches Analysis

Most common words:

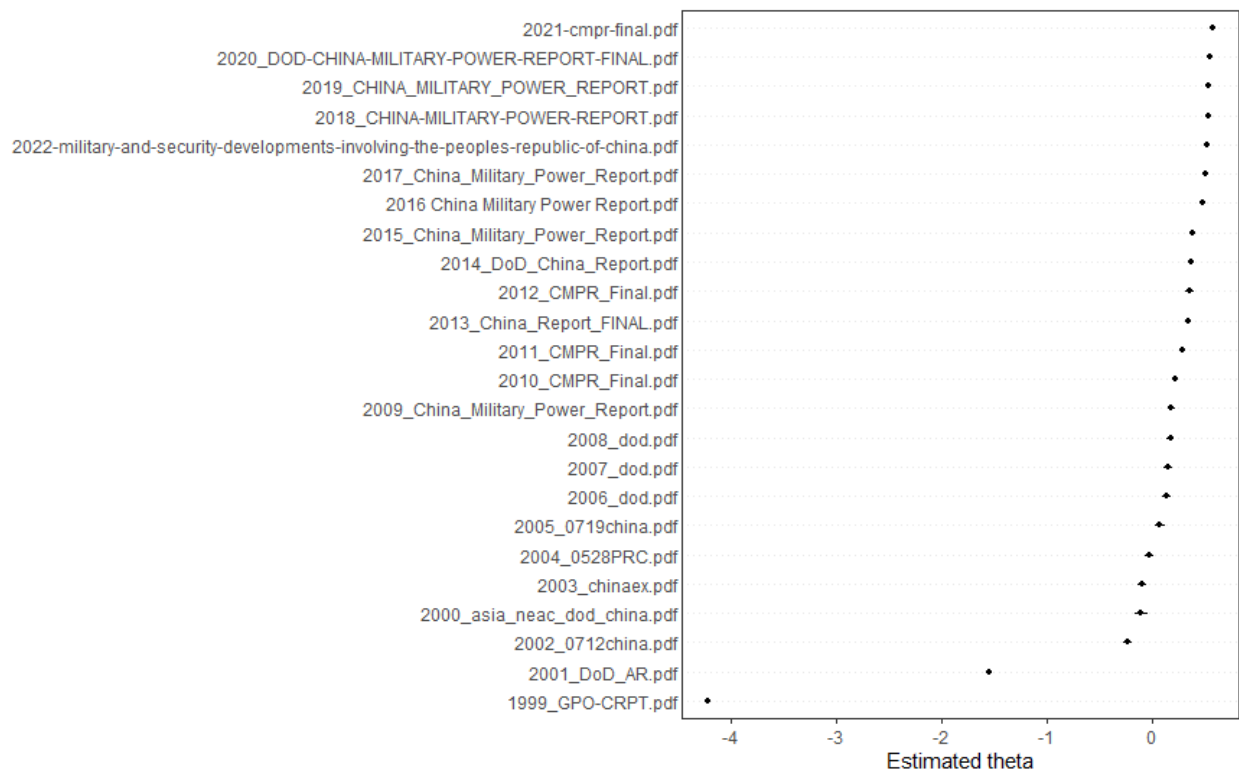
people	government	us	can
592	575	507	489
must	upon	great	may
377	371	354	343
states	world	nation	country
343	329	324	323
shall	every	one	peace
316	309	274	259
new	power	now	public
256	246	238	227
time	america	citizens	united
223	220	217	211
constitution	nations	union	freedom
210	199	190	188
free	american		
187	185		



Some similarities over time and between presidents is that they use words to give a sense of community like *us*, *nation*, *united*, and *Americans*. Many presidents over the years try to promote unity and patriotism in their speeches through this language. Almost all presidents, regardless of the time, use *freedom*, *peace*, and *union* to relate to the core founding ideas of the United States and the first amendment of the Constitution.

The differences over time usually incorporate the main events of their specific time period in their speeches. For example, during the time of the civil rights movement, there was a greater emphasis on justice and peace. In recent years, there has been more focus on the economy and hope. Among presidents, each one has their own style, and their words match this pattern. For instance, Ronald Reagan and Donald Trump are more action focused and will use direct language and focus on achievements while Barack Obama is more aspirational and will use more hopeful and inclusive language.

Wordfish is a text scaling model that is used to quantify policy ideas and show political stances on specific issues.



This wordfish describes how America views China as a military power over the years. The shift from little acknowledgement of their power in 1999 to a more serious threat in 2001 was likely due to the terrorist attack of 9/11 and increased international security around America. After that time, there was a steady increase in how strongly Americans viewed China as a threat.

To compare positions, you must look at plot positions over time and by each group; analyzing the word differences lets you get the best understanding of what the wordfish is trying to portray. Looking at the plot over time shows trends and differences over a period. Looking at the plot by group lets you compare categories and recognize if a specific group has clustered or is more spread out. There are other scaling methods to use including latent semantic analysis, or LSAs, that look at themes rather than only ideologies, structural topic models, or STMs, that look at topics and use documents that fit that topic, and wordscore which uses texts with already established political positions. It is important to use other scaling methods to compare documents objectively, communicate which words create differences, and quantifiably measure each document.